Martin Luther and the Reformation

Luther and the Protestant Reformation

Martin Luther was the most important figure in initiating the Protestant Reformation. The Protestant Reformation is certainly the most important political and theological and religious change in Christianity in the last five or perhaps ten centuries, certainly since Eastern Orthodox Christianity split off. The Protestant Reformation is largely a northern European response to the Catholic Church, to its abuses. It is most popular in the northern parts of Europe. It ultimately becomes dominant in the Scandinavian Peninsula and in England and in the northern parts of Germany. Luther is the leading light of the Reformation.

There is no one who is more important in generating the tremendous political and theological and military consequences of these changes from the pre-Reformation church to the church that has to deal with these new reformed Protestant religions. He is important for a number of reasons. He was the leading light of the Reformation, the spark that generated its wider movement. There are earlier reformers who attempt to reform Catholicism from within, but they fail fairly continuously in the previous century.

Luther initially did not intend to provoke the kind of political and military dislocation that was associated with the Protestant Reformation. In fact, he is an extremely conservative thinker. What Luther intended to do was to cleanse the church of borrowings and of traditions that had insinuated themselves within the body of church doctrine for which there is no scriptural justification. Luther's famous phrase, sola fide, sola scriptura, means “by faith alone” and “by Scripture alone”. A human being is justified in God’s sight and saved only in the Augustinian sense by faith and by Scripture. It is not possible to achieve this through works, rituals, or traditions that had accumulated within Catholicism.

He lived between 1483 and 1546, but his great achievement or the achievement for which he is most noted is the publication of the 95 Theses in 1517. He was a biblical scholar. He was a professor of biblical theology. For that reason, disputation was a normal part of his activities as a scholar. But the very ignitable substance of his theses generated a political firestorm that Luther himself never anticipated. The theses concerned the contemporary practice of selling indulgences.

Indulgences and Luther’s Religious Crisis

An indulgence must be understood in order to see the force of Luther’s criticism. The idea that God judges people when they die and sends them either to heaven or hell was supplemented by the idea of purgatory, a place where people who had not committed damnable sins but were not sanctified in God's sight could work off their punishment and eventually become sanctified. Certain elements within the Catholic Church seized upon this idea. Politically ambitious popes who needed money to finance wars and other activities decided to sell indulgences. An indulgence functioned like a certificate promising release from punishment. A purchaser could present it as evidence that the required penalty had been paid. This practice was profoundly inconsistent with the Christian message. Luther regarded the abuse as intolerable.

We cannot put up with this. Luther himself was an extraordinarily devout individual. His piety was profoundly serious. For most of his early life, he was an ordinary Catholic. His sins were not remarkable. He was unlike the young Augustine, whose early life he regarded as morally wayward.

His relatively ordinary sins did not prevent a powerful religious faith from leading him to become an Augustinian friar. Consider what it meant to be an Augustinian friar. It differs from a Dominican or a Jesuit or any of the other orders within Catholicism. To be an Augustinian meant following the Augustinian tradition. Luther knew Augustine's work very thoroughly. He knew The City of God. He knew The Confessions. He knew some of Augustine's theological work and the emphasis that we find in Augustine on, first of all, human depravity, that irremediable problem of human original sin, which means that we have to wait for God's inscrutable grace in order to be saved. That idea is borrowed from Augustine and radicalised in Luther because God's inscrutable grace will turn out to be the key towards developing the sort of religious faith by which you can be saved.

Religious faith, in this account, is the only thing that saves a believer. Erik H. Erikson examined Luther’s early life and conversion in Young Man Luther. As a psychiatrist and psychologist, Erikson connected Luther’s decision to become an Augustinian monk with his personal development and experience of fear.

During a thunderstorm, a nearby tree was struck by lightning. Luther cried out in panic, “By Saint Anne, I will become a monk if I am spared.” He survived, and his religious seriousness led him to honor the vow. He was sufficiently devout to take his oath uttered under great duress seriously. He decided that he would give up a promising career in the law, because he had a legal education prior to entering holy orders. And he decided that he would devote himself to God and to celestial things, but particularly he wanted an order which would be particularly rigorous and strict. He wanted, insofar as possible, to remove himself from earthly temptations. His identity as an Augustinian friar helps explain why his later theology centered on sin, grace, and faith, central themes that he took directly from Augustine, modernized, and placed in a new context. Luther’s religiosity was powerful and fervent.

Worms and the Authority of Conscience

In 1521, at the Diet of Worms, Luther was asked to recant what the Church regarded as heresy. He was told that he would be driven out of his academic and ecclesiastical position, and in fact he would suffer the fate of all heretics. Luther made a dangerous and courageous decision: “Here I stand; I can do no other.” He demanded that his opponents prove him wrong by Scripture. That was a tremendously dangerous and courageous decision. It is very clear that Martin Luther has a powerful and independent conscience, and he insists that religious belief and matters of personal conscience are central, and that you cannot be saved by any sort of ritual adherence, by any sort of externality. It is only the state of your soul and your willingness to lay everything on the line for your religious beliefs that makes possible salvation.

Salvation is given to those who receive God's grace and are saved by faith alone. Before he wrote and published the 95 Theses, Luther spent a great deal of time studying Scripture and writing about it. His commentaries on Romans and the Psalms emphasized faith, particularly the passage in Romans 1:17 stating that the righteous shall live by faith. Luther spent a great deal of time meditating on Romans. Romans was clearly Luther’s favorite of Paul’s epistles. Its importance for Luther lay in its emphasis on faith,

which allowed him to reject the doctrine of works that had gradually entered Christianity and become a decisive element in the Catholic understanding of Scripture. One consequence was Luther's contempt for reason. He often believed that the tradition of Athens led people astray.

It's not that he was incapable of understanding Aristotle or Plato. He had a very deep and powerful intellect. The problem was that, as he described it, reason was "the devil's whore" and he thought that Aristotle had led Christianity astray and that the scholastics had done a great evil to Christian believers by trying to reconcile Athens and Jerusalem through scholastic logic chopping.

What Luther is trying to do is break through that scholastic logic chopping and get rid of that Aristotelian tradition. The downside of this, apart from perhaps its contemptuous connection to reason and to the Athenian tradition, is the fact that there's a certain sort of messianic tendency in Luther. In a letter of 1522, he stated that he would not allow his doctrine to be judged by anyone, even by angels. He further claimed that anyone who did not accept his doctrine could not attain salvation. That's a rather grand claim for someone who is not trying to spark a tremendous political and moral and intellectual upheaval in Western Europe. He certainly seems to vacillate between uncertainty in himself and an absolute certainty in his own righteousness when he feels that he is infused with the Spirit of God. The problem is that, from the outside, it is sometimes difficult to decide how to assess this. It has attractive and unattractive qualities. His theological work was enormous.

The Three Great Treatises of 1520

Luther, like so many German philosophers, produced a great many publications. He wrote a vast body of work on a wide range of biblical texts. Three texts from 1520, written shortly before Luther appeared at the Diet of Worms, are especially important. He had already published the theses in 1517. He has sparked a kind of controversy in intellectual circles and in ecclesiastical circles in Western Europe. And he is now trying to appeal to various audiences with various kinds of arguments.

The way Luther phrased his arguments, the language he used, and the kinds of arguments he made formed something analogous to a Copernican revolution in religion. What Copernicus was to astronomy, Luther was in some respects to religion: he changed the entire orientation. He made us think that what previously had been settled and fixed was in flux and dynamic. He made us think that what was previously in flux and in change and becoming now became fixed. We move from a conception of religiosity and a conception of salvation, which is centred around the group, centred around the institution of the church in particular, and centred around the sacraments, to a new conception of religiosity, a new conception of salvation, and a new perspective on how to think about religious matters. The movement was from the group to the individual and from the outside to the inside. We move from a doctrine of works and a doctrine perhaps corrupt, like selling indulgences, to a doctrine that is incorruptible, one would hope, the doctrine that by faith alone, by a change infused in your soul by the grace of God, as the way to salvation.

We have fundamentally changed the perspective that Western Europe has on the process by which people are saved and justified, but also implicit in that is the fact that for the first time, the great weight of Catholic tradition, the great institutional burden of the Catholic church, has been lifted from Western Europe. And not just from the kings

and princes who ran Western Europe, it has been lifted from the individual. You no longer need the mediation of the church in order to find out what Scripture says. You no longer need rituals such as penance, marriage, or other practices that Luther considered unscriptural as the primary avenue to holiness. In fact, as the gospel says, the kingdom of God is within us. Luther argued that, if the kingdom of God was to be found, it could only be found in the soul. No one else could know the state of that soul; only the individual and God could know it.

God's inscrutable grace gives a person faith, and by faith alone is that person saved. The first of Luther’s great treatises of 1520 is To the Christian Nobility of the German Nation, and it was written in German. This was very unusual.

The printing press is a relatively new invention and is going to have enormous implications for the Protestant Reformation. One reason is that one of the things that impeded the progress of the Reformation of the church in earlier centuries was the difficulty of disseminating these doctrines. The church was quite effective at finding troublemakers, at finding heretical firebrands, and eliminating them. Although authorities could find Luther, they could not find all of his books or all of the printing presses. The technology of communication therefore helped the Reformation spread. The movement began as a theological dispute, but it acquired political and military consequences and expanded to encompass Western culture.

The dispute began as a theological problem but expanded to encompass all of Western culture. In To the Christian Nobility of the German Nation, Luther effectively ended the Middle Ages by challenging the distinction between social and spiritual classes. He undoes the distinction between the spiritual classes and the secular classes. It had been the case that clerics had been only accountable to the church. They had been covered only by canon law, and there were a special set of regulations that covered them, and they did not directly report to the secular civil authorities. Luther rejected this arrangement. In fact, there's no distinction between the spiritual classes and the secular classes. He argues instead for the priesthood of all believers, and this is part of that Copernican Revolution.

There was a time when most people would have to go to a priest for absolution, would have to go to a priest for the things that will make it possible to enter the domain of religious salvation, would make it be part of the Christian community. No longer is that necessary. Since we have the priesthood of all believers, we no longer need a separate clerical class with separate identities and separate laws and a separate set of institutions that applies to them. This, in some ways, is the institutional and theological end of the Middle Ages. Once everyone is a priest, it raises the question of, why do we need bishops and priests and deacons and abbots and monks? And it would seem that if all are priests, if all Christian believers are priests, the necessary conclusion that we are to draw is that the institutions of the church are corrupt and the priests that they support are superfluous. This is obviously a revolutionary doctrine.

In addition to going after the distinction between the secular and spiritual classes, Luther also attacks and undermines the papal claim to being the sole authority for interpreting Scripture. He argued that all Christian believers should have access to the Word, and the idea of restricting access to the Word to an authoritative and self-appointed group of interpreters is both unscriptural and unchristian because it impedes the progress of religious conversion and religious devotion within the souls of the individual believers. Clearly, this is going to tend to undermine the claims of the

papacy, first of all, and if you're going to make all of the Catholic clergy irrelevant, this also undermines the validity of the papacy as well.

Since it appears to Luther that the papacy is an unscriptural usurpation of power within the church, he understands himself to be cleansing the church of tyrannous traditions that it has accumulated despite the injunctions of Scripture. So Luther does not, initially at least, think of himself as a revolutionary. He thinks of himself, in fact, as an old-fashioned kind of reformer. He feels that the right thing to do is to drive the church back to its roots, to eliminate those pagan holdovers which he associates with Rome itself. And most importantly in this book, and this is the third big issue that gets raised in To the Christian Nobility of the German Nation, Luther attacks the power of the papacy over secular rulers. And this was a stroke of genius.

It is uncertain whether Luther was making deliberate political calculations. He was deeply immersed in theological questions and extraordinarily devout. Yet it is striking that, in a theological treatise intended to break the papacy’s hold over individual believers, he appealed to the nominally Christian princes, kings, and political officials who ruled fragmented Germany. He reminded them that they had previously sent tithes, indulgence payments, taxes, and other funds to Rome. The rulers’ reasoning could be expressed as follows: “What if that is a usurpation? We get to keep all that money. We get to keep all that power. And not only is that politically useful, it is scriptural. It is divine. It is approved of by God.” A comforting doctrine like that cannot help but find a happy audience in German politicians.

The farther rulers were from Rome, the more attractive this argument became. Lutheranism made its greatest inroads in northern Germany. The farther a territory was from Rome, the more likely the Protestant Reformation was to succeed there. The closer a territory was to Rome, the easier it was for papal authorities to maintain control. A doctrine like this is very tempting, even for those who have not been saved by faith alone. a second great work from 1520, before he goes on, it's just after he finishes to the Christian nobility in August.

The Babylonian Captivity of the Church

In October, Luther wrote The Babylonian Captivity of the Church. The title recalls the Babylonian destruction of Jerusalem and the biblical account of the chosen people being enslaved by a pagan king who acts as God’s instrument of punishment. Luther directed the work toward a clerical audience. Because this work addressed a different audience, it made different arguments. He writes it in Latin, and very clearly, he's writing it for educated people, and that means essentially clerics at the time that he's writing. Luther wrote The Babylonian Captivity of the Church in an attempt to win over clerics who were receptive to the new idea of the priesthood of all believers. In this work, he attacked the sacramental system. The Catholic Church recognizes seven sacraments.

After looking over scripture very carefully, Luther concludes that only, initially he concludes that three of the sacraments are valid and four are not valid. The ones he thinks are valid are the Lord's Supper, baptism, and confession. Towards the end of his life, confession or the sacrament of penance is given up as also being unscriptural. At the end of his life, Luther recognized only two of the seven sacraments. He argued that the sacramental system was unscriptural and that every true sacrament was a form of the Word. This may seem like an innocuous or vague idea, but its implications were revolutionary.

If sacraments are forms of the Word, and the Word has been given to all Christian believers as their common property, then a special clerical group is no longer required to administer them. The implications were decidedly anticlerical and sufficiently revolutionary to generate repercussions across Western Europe. Henry VIII responded by publishing under his name The Defence of the Seven Sacraments, which was in fact written by Thomas More. The work was provoked by Luther's attack on the sacraments.

The debate involved reformers who sought radical changes within the Church, moderates such as Erasmus and Thomas More who favored limited reforms, and reactionaries who defended practices such as the sale of indulgences. The moderates failed to preserve the center and prevent schism and the wars of the Reformation. The third of Luther's great works from 1520 was The Freedom of a Christian Man, one of the great landmarks in the history of Western theology.

The Freedom of a Christian Man

It is a conciliatory open letter to Pope Leo, and this is very different in tone from the earlier two works because they are far from conciliatory, they are quite belligerent. By writing this conciliatory letter, Luther sought to avoid condemnation as a heretic and to prevent a formal Protestant schism. What he wants to do is cleanse the church and get rid of these many abuses. Luther did not wish to cause internal discord or military conflict. He preferred to keep these reforms within the framework of the Church and still believed that this was possible. The Freedom of a Christian Man was written in Latin, although Luther later translated it into German so that it could reach a wider audience. He argued that, without faith, a person is completely egocentric and incapable of free will.

This was essentially an Augustinian argument. We need God's inscrutable grace. If you think about Book 7 of Augustine's Confessions, where he has intellectually understood that Manichaeanism is wrong and that Catholicism is the right doctrine, and yet he is unable to make the jump until Book 8, when he reads Scripture and the grace of God infuses into him. The central claim is that faith and salvation depend upon God's grace. Luther is borrowing those Augustinian themes and radicalising them here in the freedom of a Christian man.

Before receiving God's grace, freedom was therefore impossible in this account. We are all enslaved to this world. We are all the creatures of sin. This was a radical interpretation of original sin. There's no such thing as free will among the vast majority of the world. Only those who are given God's grace have free will. There's no guarantee that they will use their free will properly. It's entirely possible, once God illuminates your life, that you should go out and do wicked things. But then, and only then, do you have the choice of whether you shall do good or whether you shall do evil. Before that transformation, the human being lacks the freedom to desire the good and remains condemned.

This idea would later be developed in a different form in Kant's moral theory. Kant later argues that the only good thing is a good will. Well, it turns out that many of the kind of embryonic ideas of German philosophy are going to be founded by Luther. Although he is an important theologian and an important political figure, do not underestimate the significance of his philosophical contributions. They have to be changed somewhat and modified in the course of Western history. But many of the protean ideas that will be found here, dig through it.

Faith, Works, and the German Idea of Freedom

Taking these books together, a doctrine of faith as opposed to works. And this is Luther's way of jettisoning Aristotle, jettisoning the tradition of Athens, which he thinks has adulterated and corrupted the tradition of Western Christianity. Aristotle argues in the Nicomachean Ethics that a good person develops good habits and habitually does good things. Luther rejected this connection between good works and the status of the person before God. He says that there's no necessary connection between being a good man and doing works that we would be inclined to describe as praiseworthy. It is entirely possible to do good things and be an evil man, and it is also possible to be an evil man and have the grace of God infuse you just before you die, and you may not have done any good works. There is no necessary connection between faith and works.

He is moving away from a doctrine of externalities. He is also giving up on Aristotle and giving up on the Aristotelian tradition that has been incorporated into scholastic philosophy. Considering what the previous three or four or five hundred years of Western religious and philosophical development were like, they were all the incorporation of the Aristotelian tradition into the tradition of Christian religion. Luther rejected this inherited synthesis as corrupt and unnecessary for salvation. In addition to formulating powerful critical and theological doctrines, he profoundly influenced what one historian called the German idea of freedom.

What by the German idea of freedom is this. The growth of personal political freedoms has been one of the main themes in the last five hundred years of Western philosophy. And there have been different strands, conceptions of what freedom might be. In the Anglo-American tradition, we have a connection between freedom and democracy. It develops actually later in the history of political thought. In the German tradition, we don't see that. Luther connects freedom to individuality and to individual conscience. But you will note that when these states become free of the papacy and free of the control of the Catholic Church, they still have these old quasi-feudal hierarchies left in them. The removal of ecclesiastical hierarchy did not by itself connect this freedom with democracy.

Within the tradition of German political thought, there is no obvious or foundational connection between freedom and democracy. And this is going to have the greatest and most important consequences for the later development of German thought. Think of someone like Hegel, who's always talking about the philosophy of freedom and the gradual increase in freedom in the West. Hegel thought he was a good Lutheran. Hegel was not a Democrat.

Luther, Language, and the Bible

Further examination of Luther’s work reveals his formative influence on the German language. His influence on German is incalculable. He stood at the intersection of a major theological controversy and a new communications technology. He is in the midst, at the centre, of a theological controversy which involves all of Europe and particularly involves all of German speaking Europe. The printing press is in place now so that his words can be magnified and amplified and pushed all across German speaking Europe. The key thing here is that Luther has as much influence on the development of the written or printed German language as Shakespeare has on the written, printed development of the English language. He stood at the intersection of a major theological controversy and a new communications technology.

He is the canonical stylist, the first great stylist of the German language. And this has tremendous influence on the subsequent development of German philosophy but also on the subsequent development of the language itself. Beyond that, he makes an argument, or I'd be inclined to say, that he was, within the German vernacular, the first great writer. Prior to that time, virtually all writing had been clerical and in Latin. Luther's works became the first great set of bestsellers. Bestsellers about the sacraments may now seem unusual, but within the contemporary climate of opinion and intellectual life, few subjects could have appeared more important or interesting.

Luther was a bestselling author in addition to being a theologian and a political figure. Luther was a bestselling author, in addition to being a theologian and a political figure. He generated a number of very interesting readings of the Bible, and most importantly, he translated the Bible from Latin into German, and this is of great consequence. Shakespeare is important in English, but the Bible is even more foundational not just in English but also in German. Luther's translation became the German translation of the Bible and the German version of Christianity. Although the use of the vernacular could obscure some intellectual elements of biblical research, it also made the Bible a powerful democratic force. People could obtain Luther's Bible, read it, and decide for themselves what they believed: sola fide, sola scriptura, by faith alone and by Scripture alone.

We need both. Luther makes that possible. In his preface to the German translation of the Bible, he makes a number of very interesting arguments, and he states some of his hermeneutic principles, which turn out to be of great use when we go back and read his theological writings. He first warned readers not to make a Moses out of Christ. This was a peculiar idea in some respects, and its meaning depends on how it is interpreted.

On one level, the claim is clear. If the idea is that Christ adds something to the Mosaic law, the new covenant adds something to the old covenant, and we've superseded somehow the idea of “an eye for an eye, a tooth for a tooth”, well then, I can understand what he's driving at there. On the other hand, there are certain Gospels. Consider the Gospel of Matthew, which is organized into five parts as an imitation of the Pentateuch, and we have a constant replacement and addition of Christ's injunctions to the Mosaic injunctions. The pattern of Jesus’ statements in Matthew can be represented as follows: “You have heard X, but I tell you Y”; “You have heard A, but I tell you B”. The connection between the law of Jesus and the law of Moses is very complex. Luther tended to go to one extreme. There would be arguments that you could make in both ways, but the stance that Luther takes has very much to do with the way in which he reads Scripture and the hierarchy that he creates of the books of the Bible, which in some ways are a very unique and interesting contribution.

Luther described these as the truest and noblest books of the New Testament. The basis on which he identified them as the truest and noblest is unclear. His argument concerned their theological primacy, rather than the possibility that a spurious book had been inserted into the Bible. Luther was making an argument about theological primacy, supremacy, or importance, although the basis for proving such a proposition is unclear. He ranked the books of the Bible as follows: the best and most important were John's Gospel, the First Epistle of John, and then Paul, especially Romans, Galatians, and Ephesians.

He spends a tremendous amount of time glossing Paul to the Romans. The central ideas can be expressed as follows: “You will be saved by faith alone” and “Your faith has saved you”. Only faith can save a person. The Pauline version of Christianity became the Lutheran version of Christianity in an intensified form. Paul was the decisive influence

on Luther's conception of Scripture. He likes Peter's first epistle as well, and then everything else is a great downhill slide once we get past his favorite books of the Bible. And it's remarkable what he leaves out here. All three of the synoptic Gospels are of secondary significance, which is a remarkable turn of events, and it's a very peculiar theological stance.

In addition, Luther described the Epistle of James as an “epistle of straw”. This meant that he did not accept its emphasis. He rejected it because James appeared to say that works, rather than faith, would save a person. You can see why, if you want to make the argument that it's only faith that will save you, not works, that you want to get rid of that. Here's the difficulty. How does one go about finding out which of the epistles are the straw ones? Isn't this really a Procrustean way of going back and saying: “Here are the books of the Bible that are consistent with my theological views, and here are the ones that are inconsistent”? After making this distinction, the argument still maintains that Scripture alone and faith alone will save a person. This involves a considerable amount of selective argument, although Luther was not alone in using it.

His Catholic antagonists are at least as bad and at least as disingenuous in attempting to refute him. But there is a certain amount of, if not arbitrariness, a certain amount of, well, uncomfortably messianic certainty about what the true and important books of the Bible are. And the idea of informing the world that the synoptics are just not all that important is not easy to find convincing. The proposition may have served a useful purpose, but its basis remains difficult to establish. Fifteen centuries after the texts were written, it is difficult to determine which of the four Gospels is the best. There is therefore a degree of flexibility in Luther’s ranking, although a charitable reading is possible. He was trying to direct people who were ignorant of Scripture toward texts that could offer immediate edification. He probably did not intend to eliminate any biblical books, but he engaged in a tremendous amount of overt and dubious special pleading to avoid the implications of the Epistle of James. Because James emphasizes works, considerable interpretive effort is required to sustain the claim that it is a “straw” epistle.

Luther’s Political Theology and the Individual

Luther’s political theology completes this examination of his thought. He was not primarily a political thinker, yet he arguably influenced the development of Western political thought as profoundly as a figure such as Marx. Everyone had to respond to him. Within the century, you had to either be a Lutheran or an anti-Lutheran, but everyone had some opinion. You could not remain indifferent to the challenges presented by the Protestant Reformation. It split Christianity in a way that was unprecedented, and it generated this whole series of political and military interventions that did justice and did credit to neither side.

A third of the population of Germany was killed during the wars of the Reformation. So that means that they lose not just people, but also property and also the advantages of civilization and culture, which they may have accumulated during that century. So everyone on both sides wants to point the finger at the other and wants to lay the blame at someone else's door. The repercussions of the Lutheran Reformation became everyone’s problem and responsibility, and much of the behavior on both sides did credit to neither. Luther was, strangely enough, an authoritarian political thinker. This tendency is visible in the forceful tone of his theological writing. But also, he never really

shrugged off the traditions of hierarchy. He didn't threaten, for example, landed aristocracy. He didn't develop the democratic political implications that are buried in the marrow of Protestantism.

Luther rejected these implications and wrote vehemently against the democratic tendencies within the Reformation. In 1523, he published On Governmental Authority, in which his position was consistently authoritarian. Later in his life, his works became even more explicitly authoritarian. In 1525, he published Against the Murdering, Thieving Hordes of Peasants. The turmoil of the period brought many underlying conflicts to the surface. Many of the discontents of the German peasantry had found a vehicle for expression during the turmoil connected with the Reformation. Luther was horrified by this. He thought that God had created the political order in a hierarchical, stable way. The idea of the peasants thieving and murdering and undermining the political structure of society was anathema to Luther. Luther said that the German nobility would be perfectly justified in cutting them down and that they should be repressed mercilessly. So his work on the murdering, thieving hordes of peasants justifies the violent suppression of these peasants.

For Luther, justice in this world was always retributive. It was not to rehabilitate people. It was to give them back what they deserved. Luther regarded strict authoritarian justice as the only way to keep the lid on this boiling pot. He expressed the idea through the striking image that “frogs must have their storks”: God had not created storks without a purpose. The frogs, in this metaphor, must therefore submit to the storks. Otherwise, they will be impaled. Luther was therefore not a democratic political thinker, yet few figures did more to prepare later developments in Western political freedom.

Luther himself was an authoritarian thinker. Within the next several generations, however, Protestant thinkers began to draw conclusions from his reading of the Bible and from the radical implications of his anticlerical tendencies. Anabaptism is one example. There are a whole series of Protestant sects which are generated in the wake of Luther's work, which Luther would have thought atrocious. He would have thought them evil because they were a threat to political stability. He was not intending to democratize politics here. He sought to liberate theology and the soul rather than the body or the political order. He still expected people to pay taxes to their existing rulers, provided those rulers did not use them for papal purposes. Luther, while he himself is a seminal thinker in the West, refused to draw out the implications of his own doctrine. It was only in subsequent generations that those doctrines were worked out. This is central to the significance of the Lutheran Reformation.

Luther is one of the pivotal figures in the history of Western thought because he did something necessary for the subsequent development of intellectual life: he legitimized the individual ego. Before Luther, identity had been shaped primarily by a sense of corporate community. A person belonged to a family, town, village, and church. And in the process of being part of this corporate community, being part of the church, one's identity was largely corporate. It wasn't quite as individualistic as Luther's direct connection to God will be and direct infusion of God's faith will be.

More importantly, this development set the stage for later Western thought. The connection between Luther’s liberation of the individual soul and the Enlightenment’s liberation of the individual citizen can be difficult to see because Luther expressed his arguments in theological terms. By the time of Locke and other natural rights and social contract thinkers of the Enlightenment, these ideas had largely been secularized. If one follows the movement from an argument made in theological terms to an argument made

in secular terms, you will see a direct connection between the democratizing and liberating tendencies of the Lutheran revolution and the democratizing and liberating tendencies which are extended over a much wider domain when we come to the political theory of the Enlightenment. The argument is that when Luther legitimizes the individual ego by faith alone, by scripture alone, you are responsible for your own salvation. When he eliminates the impediments presented by the church and a corrupt clerical group to your connection to God, what he has done is liberated just your spiritual and soul aspects.

In the Enlightenment, this soul would be transformed into the Cartesian cogito. In Descartes' Discourse on Method and Meditations on First Philosophy, the ego that is left when he begins to examine himself is, in fact, a legacy of Martin Luther. It is the free individual self that has been turned into a legitimate locus of political demands by Martin Luther. Luther didn't intend it to be political in its implications. He didn't understand the wider secularizing implications of his step. He was attempting to liberate the soul so it could get nearer to God. In the history of Western thought, unintended consequences are at least as important as intended ones. By advancing the principles sola fide and sola scriptura, Luther shifted the center of moral responsibility from the group to the individual. When this argument was extended beyond religion into politics and morality, it helped to form the foundation of Enlightenment political theory.

Luther's idea of the priesthood of all believers is the initial wedge that gets driven into the unity of scholastic society and scholastic philosophy. When he splits off the church from the body of believers, when he splits off the priesthood from those that are saved, what he is beginning to do is split off all arbitrary hierarchies from the mass population, from the citizenry as a whole. Luther can therefore be understood as a bridge between two historical worlds. Luther was a bridge from the static society and static self of the Middle Ages, including the imitatio Christi of medieval monasticism, to the characteristically modern idea of the rights of man. The modern world of the individual, in which rights of citizenship are extended to all members of human society, can be understood as an extrapolation and radicalization of Luther's liberation of the individual ego. He therefore represented a step, perhaps only a half-step, toward the universal rights of man, which developed over the following two or three centuries and reached their fruition in the French Revolution.